Dear Wife,

We have now reached the moment of decision. I have concentrated here at Naseby camp all the resources Heaven has left me, and I write to you in haste from thence. Here I await the army of my rebellious subjects. I am about to struggle for the last time with them. If victorious, I shall continue the struggle; if beaten, I am lost. I shall try, in the latter case (alas! in our position, one must provide for everything), I shall try to gain the coast of France. But can they, will they receive an unhappy king, who will bring such a sad story into a country already agitated by civil discord? Your wisdom and your affection must serve me as guides. The bearer of this letter will tell you, madame, what I dare not trust to pen and paper and the risks of transit. He will explain to you the steps that I expect you to pursue. I charge him also with my blessing for my children and with the sentiments of my soul for yourself, my dearest sweetheart.

The letter bore the signature, not of 'Charles, King,' but of 'Charles—still king.'

'And let him be no longer king,' cried the queen. 'Let him be conquered, exiled, proscribed, provided he still lives. Alas! in these days the throne is too dangerous a place for me to wish him to retain it. But my lord, tell me,' she continued, 'hide nothing from me—what is, in truth, the king's position? Is it as hopeless as he thinks?'

'Alas! madame, more hopeless than he thinks. His majesty has so good a heart that he cannot understand hatred; is so loyal that he does not suspect treason! England is torn in twain by a spirit of disturbance which, I greatly fear, blood alone can exorcise.'

'But Lord Montrose,' replied the queen, 'I have heard of his great and rapid successes of battles gained. I heard it said that he was marching to the frontier to join the king.'

'Yes, madame; but on the frontier he was met by Lesly; he had tried victory by means of superhuman undertakings. Now victory has abandoned him. Montrose, beaten at Philiphaugh, was obliged to disperse the

remains of his army and to fly, disguised as a servant. He is at Bergen, in Norway.'

'Heaven preserve him!' said the queen. 'It is at least a consolation to know that some who have so often risked their lives for us are safe. And now, my lord, that I see how hopeless the position of the king is, tell me with what you are charged on the part of my royal husband.'

'Well, then, madame,' said De Winter, 'the king wishes you to try and discover the dispositions of the king and queen toward him.'

'Alas! you know that even now the king is but a child and the queen a woman weak enough. Here, Monsieur Mazarin is everything.'

'Does he desire to play the part in France that Cromwell plays in England?'

'Oh, no! He is a subtle, conscienceless Italian, who though he very likely dreams of crime, dares not commit it; and unlike Cromwell, who disposes of both Houses, Mazarin has had the queen to support him in his struggle with the parliament.'

'More reason, then, he should protect a king pursued by parliament.'

The queen shook her head despairingly.

'If I judge for myself, my lord,' she said, 'the cardinal will do nothing, and will even, perhaps, act against us. The presence of my daughter and myself in France is already irksome to him; much more so would be that of the king. My lord,' added Henrietta, with a melancholy smile, 'it is sad and almost shameful to be obliged to say that we have passed the winter in the Louvre without money, without linen, almost without bread, and often not rising from bed because we wanted fire.'

'Horrible!' cried De Winter; 'the daughter of Henry IV, and the wife of King Charles! Wherefore did you not apply, then, madame, to the first person you saw from us?'

'Such is the hospitality shown to a queen by the minister from whom a king demands it.'

'But I heard that a marriage between the Prince of Wales and Mademoiselle d'Orléans was spoken of,' said De Winter.

'Yes, for an instant I hoped it was so. The young people felt a mutual esteem; but the queen, who at first sanctioned their affection, changed her mind, and Monsieur, the Duc d'Orléans, who had encouraged the familiarity between them, has forbidden his daughter to think any more

about the union. Oh, my lord!' continued the queen, without restraining her tears, 'it is better to fight as the king has done, and to die, as perhaps he will, than live in beggary like me.'

'Courage, madame! courage! Do not despair! The interests of the French crown, endangered at this moment, are to discountenance rebellion in a neighbouring nation. Mazarin, as a statesman, will understand the politic necessity.'

'Are you sure,' said the queen doubtfully, 'that you have not been forestalled?'

'By whom?'

'By the Joices, the Prinns, the Cromwells?'

'By a tailor, a coachmaker, a brewer! Ah! I hope, madame, that the cardinal will not enter into negotiations with such men!'

'Ah! what is he himself?' asked Madame Henrietta.

'But for the honour of the king—of the queen.'

'Well, let us hope he will do something for the sake of their honour,' said the queen. 'A true friend's eloquence is so powerful, my lord, that you have reassured me. Give me your hand and let us go to the minister; and yet,' she added, 'suppose he should refuse and that the king loses the battle?'

'His majesty will then take refuge in Holland, where I hear his highness the Prince of Wales now is.'

'And can his majesty count upon many such subjects as yourself for his flight?'

'Alas! no, madame,' answered De Winter; 'but the case is provided for and I am come to France to seek allies.'

'Allies!' said the queen, shaking her head.

'Madame,' replied De Winter, 'provided I can find some of my good old friends of former times I will answer for anything.'

'Come then, my lord,' said the queen, with the painful doubt that is felt by those who have suffered much; 'come, and may Heaven hear you.'

who refused to accompany him unless I made this sacrifice. We are now reduced to live at the expense of these daughters of Heaven; we are the poor, succoured by God.'

'But why not address yourself to your sister, the queen?' asked the girl.

'Alas! the queen, my sister, is no longer queen, my child. Another reigns in her name. One day you will be able to understand how all this is.'

'Well, then, to the king, your nephew. Shall I speak to him? You know how much he loves me, my mother.'

'Alas! my nephew is not yet king, and you know Laporte has told us twenty times that he himself is in need of almost everything.'

'Then let us pray to Heaven,' said the girl.

The two women who thus knelt in united prayer were the daughter and grand-daughter of Henry IV, the wife and daughter of Charles I.

They had just finished their double prayer, when a nun softly tapped at the door of the cell.

'Enter, my sister,' said the queen.

'I trust your majesty will pardon this intrusion on her meditations, but a foreign lord has arrived from England and waits in the parlour, demanding the honour of presenting a letter to your majesty.'

'Oh, a letter! a letter from the king, perhaps. News from your father, do you hear, Henrietta? And the name of this lord?'

'Lord de Winter.'

'Lord de Winter!' exclaimed the queen, 'the friend of my husband. Oh, bid him enter!'

And the queen advanced to meet the messenger, whose hand she seized affectionately, whilst he knelt down and presented a letter to her, contained in a case of gold.

'Ah! my lord!' said the queen, 'you bring us three things which we have not seen for a long time. Gold, a devoted friend, and a letter from the king, our husband and master.'

De Winter bowed again, unable to reply from excess of emotion.

On their side the mother and daughter retired into the embrasure of a window to read eagerly the following letter:

'Oh, God! Take my wretched life instead!'

Chapter XXXVII

Cromwell's Letter

At the very moment when the queen quitted the convent to go to the Palais Royal, a young man dismounted at the gate of this royal abode and announced to the guards that he had something of importance to communicate to Cardinal Mazarin. Although the cardinal was often tormented by fear, he was more often in need of counsel and information, and he was therefore sufficiently accessible. The true difficulty of being admitted was not to be found at the first door, and even the second was passed easily enough; but at the third watched, besides the guard and the doorkeepers, the faithful Bernouin, a Cerberus whom no speech could soften, no wand, even of gold, could charm.

It was therefore at the third door that those who solicited or were bidden to an audience underwent their formal interrogatory.

The young man having left his horse tied to the gate in the court, mounted the great staircase and addressed the guard in the first chamber.

'Cardinal Mazarin?' said he.

'Pass on,' replied the guard.

The cavalier entered the second hall, which was guarded by the musketeers and doorkeepers.

'Have you a letter of audience?' asked a porter, advancing to the new arrival.

'I have one, but not one from Cardinal Mazarin.'

'Enter, and ask for Monsieur Bernouin,' said the porter, opening the door of the third room. Whether he only held his usual post or whether it was by accident, Monsieur Bernouin was found standing behind the door and must have heard all that had passed.

'You seek me, sir,' said he. 'From whom may the letter be you bear to his eminence?'

'From General Oliver Cromwell,' said the new comer. 'Be so good as to mention this name to his eminence and to bring me word whether he will receive me—yes or no.'

Saying which, he resumed the proud and sombre bearing peculiar at that time to Puritans. Bernouin cast an inquisitorial glance at the person of the young man and entered the cabinet of the cardinal, to whom he transmitted the messenger's words.

'A man bringing a letter from Oliver Cromwell?' said Mazarin. 'And what kind of a man?'

'A genuine Englishman, your eminence. Hair sandy-red—more red than sandy; gray-blue eyes—more gray than blue; and for the rest, stiff and proud.'

'Let him give in his letter.'

'His eminence asks for the letter,' said Bernouin, passing back into the ante-chamber.

'His eminence cannot see the letter without the bearer of it,' replied the young man; 'but to convince you that I am really the bearer of a letter, see, here it is; and kindly add,' continued he, 'that I am not a simple messenger, but an envoy extraordinary.'

Bernouin re-entered the cabinet, returning in a few seconds. 'Enter, sir,' said he.

The young man appeared on the threshold of the minister's closet, in one hand holding his hat, in the other the letter. Mazarin rose. 'Have you, sir,' asked he, 'a letter accrediting you to me?'

'There it is, my lord,' said the young man.

Mazarin took the letter and read it thus:

> Mr Mordaunt, one of my secretaries, will remit this letter of introduction to His Eminence, the Cardinal Mazarin, in Paris. He is also the bearer of a second confidential epistle for his eminence.

Chapter XXXVI

A Letter from Charles the First

THE reader must now cross the Seine with us and follow us to the door of the Carmelite Convent in the Rue Saint Jacques. It is eleven o'clock in the morning and the pious sisters have just finished saying mass for the success of the armies of King Charles I Leaving the church, a woman and a young girl dressed in black, the one as a widow and the other as an orphan, have re-entered their cell.

The woman kneels on a *prie-dieu* of painted wood and at a short distance from her stands the young girl, leaning against a chair, weeping.

The woman must have once been handsome, but traces of sorrow have aged her. The young girl is lovely and her tears only embellish her; the lady appears to be about forty years of age, the girl about fourteen.

'Oh, God!' prayed the kneeling suppliant, 'protect my husband, guard my son, and take my wretched life instead!'

'Oh, God!' murmured the girl, 'leave me my mother!'

'Your mother can be of no use to you in this world, Henrietta,' said the lady, turning around. 'Your mother has no longer either throne or husband; she has neither son, money nor friends; the whole world, my poor child, has abandoned your mother!' And she fell back, weeping, into her daughter's arms.

'Courage, take courage, my dear mother!' said the girl.

'Ah! 'tis an unfortunate year for kings,' said the mother. 'And no one thinks of us in this country, for each must think about his own affairs. As long as your brother was with me he kept me up; but he is gone and can no longer send us news of himself, either to me or to your father. I have pledged my last jewels, sold your clothes and my own to pay his servants,

OLIVER CROMWELL.

'Very well, Monsieur Mordaunt,' said Mazarin, 'give me this second letter and sit down.'

The young man drew from his pocket a second letter, presented it to the cardinal, and took his seat. The cardinal, however, did not unseal the letter at once, but continued to turn it again and again in his hand; then, in accordance with his usual custom and judging from experience that few people could hide anything from him when he began to question them, fixing his eyes upon them at the same time, he thus addressed the messenger:

'You are very young, Monsieur Mordaunt, for this difficult task of ambassador, in which the oldest diplomatists often fail.'

'My lord, I am twenty-three years of age; but your eminence is mistaken in saying that I am young. I am older than your eminence, although I possess not your wisdom. Years of suffering, in my opinion, count double, and I have suffered for twenty years.'

'Ah, yes, I understand,' said Mazarin; 'want of fortune, perhaps. You are poor, are you not?' Then he added to himself: 'These English Revolutionists are all beggars and ill-bred.'

'My lord, I ought to have a fortune of six millions, but it has been taken from me.'

'You are not, then, a man of the people?' said Mazarin, astonished.

'If I bore my proper title I should be a lord. If I bore my name you would have heard one of the most illustrious names of England.'

'What is your name, then?' asked Mazarin.

'My name is Mordaunt,' replied the young man, bowing.

Mazarin now understood that Cromwell's envoy desired to retain his incognito. He was silent for an instant, and during that time he scanned the young man even more attentively than he had done at first. The messenger was unmoved.

'Devil take these Puritans,' said Mazarin aside; 'they are carved from granite.' Then he added aloud, 'But you have relations left you?'

'I have one remaining. Three times I presented myself to ask his support and three times he ordered his servants to turn me away.'

'Oh, *mon Dieu!* my dear Mr Mordaunt,' said Mazarin, hoping by a display of affected pity to catch the young man in a snare, 'how extremely your history interests me! You know not, then, anything of your birth—you have never seen your mother?'

'Yes, my lord; she came three times, whilst I was a child, to my nurse's house; I remember the last time she came as well as if it were to-day.'

'You have a good memory,' said Mazarin.

'Oh! yes, my lord,' said the young man, with such peculiar emphasis that the cardinal felt a shudder run through every vein.

'And who brought you up?' he asked again.

'A French nurse, who sent me away when I was five years old because no one paid her for me, telling me the name of a relation of whom she had heard my mother often speak.'

'What became of you?'

'As I was weeping and begging on the high road, a minister from Kingston took me in, instructed me in the Calvinistic faith, taught me all he knew himself and aided me in my researches after my family.'

'And these researches?'

'Were fruitless; chance did everything.'

'You discovered what had become of your mother?'

'I learned that she had been assassinated by my relation, aided by four friends, but I was already aware that I had been robbed of my wealth and degraded from my nobility by King Charles I.'

'Oh! I now understand why you are in the service of Cromwell; you hate the king.'

'Yes, my lord, I hate him!' said the young man.

Mazarin marked with surprise the diabolical expression with which the young man uttered these words. Just as, ordinarily, faces are coloured by blood, his face seemed dyed by hatred and became livid.

'Your history is a terrible one, Mr Mordaunt, and touches me keenly; but happily for you, you serve an all-powerful master; he ought to aid you in your search; we have so many means of gaining information.'

'My lord, to a well-bred dog it is only necessary to show one end of a track; he is certain to reach the other.'

'But this relation you mentioned—do you wish me to speak to him?' said Mazarin, who was anxious to make a friend about Cromwell's person.

'A child!' he exclaimed. 'Do you know what he has done, this child? Disguised as a monk he discovered the whole history in confession from the executioner of Bethune, and having confessed him, after having learned everything from him, he gave him absolution by planting this dagger into his heart. See, it is on fire yet with his hot blood, for it is not thirty hours since it was drawn from the wound.'

And Grimaud threw the dagger on the table.

D'Artagnan, Porthos and Aramis rose and in one spontaneous motion rushed to their swords. Athos alone remained seated, calm and thoughtful.

'And you say he is dressed as a monk, Grimaud?'

'Yes, as an Augustine monk.'

'What sized man is he?'

'About my height; thin, pale, with light blue eyes and tawny flaxen hair.'

'And he did not see Raoul?' asked Athos.

'Yes, on the contrary, they met, and it was the viscount himself who conducted him to the bed of the dying man.'

Athos, in his turn, rising without speaking, went and unhooked his sword.

'Heigh, sir,' said D'Artagnan, trying to laugh, 'do you know we look very much like a flock of silly, mouse-evading women! How is it that we, four men who have faced armies without blinking, begin to tremble at the mention of a child?'

'It is true,' said Athos, 'but this child comes in the name of Heaven.'

And very soon they left the inn.

'Please your honours,' said the host, 'a person in a great hurry wishes to speak to one of you.'

'To which of us?' asked all the four friends.

'To him who is called the Comte de la Fère.'

'It is I,' said Athos, 'and what is the name of the person?'

'Grimaud.'

'Ah!' exclaimed Athos, turning pale. 'Back already! What can have happened, then, to Bragelonne?'

'Let him enter,' cried D'Artagnan; 'let him come up.'

But Grimaud had already mounted the staircase and was waiting on the last step; so springing into the room he motioned the host to leave it. The door being closed, the four friends waited in expectation. Grimaud's agitation, his pallor, the sweat which covered his face, the dust which soiled his clothes, all indicated that he was the messenger of some important and terrible news.

'Your honours,' said he, 'that woman had a child; that child has become a man; the tigress had a little one, the tiger has roused himself; he is ready to spring upon you—beware!'

Athos glanced around at his friends with a melancholy smile. Porthos turned to look at his sword, which was hanging on the wall; Aramis seized his knife; D'Artagnan arose.

'What do you mean, Grimaud?' he exclaimed.

'That Milady's son has left England, that he is in France, on his road to Paris, if he be not here already.'

'The devil he is!' said Porthos. 'Are you sure of it?'

'Certain,' replied Grimaud.

This announcement was received in silence. Grimaud was so breathless, so exhausted, that he had fallen back upon a chair. Athos filled a beaker with champagne and gave it to him.

'Well, after all,' said D'Artagnan, 'supposing that he lives, that he comes to Paris; we have seen many other such. Let him come.'

'Yes,' echoed Porthos, glancing affectionately at his sword, still hanging on the wall; 'we can wait for him; let him come.'

'Moreover, he is but a child,' said Aramis.

Grimaud rose.

'Thanks, my lord, I will speak to him myself. He will treat me better the next time I see him.'

'You have the means, then, of touching him?'

'I have the means of making myself feared.'

Mazarin looked at the young man, but at the fire which shot from his glance he bent his head; then, embarrassed how to continue such a conversation, he opened Cromwell's letter.

The young man's eyes gradually resumed their dull and glassy appearance and he fell into a profound reverie. After reading the first lines of the letter Mazarin gave a side glance at him to see if he was watching the expression of his face as he read. Observing his indifference, he shrugged his shoulders, saying:

'Send on your business those who do theirs at the same time! Let us see what this letter contains.'

We here present the letter *verbatim:*

> To his Eminence, Monseigneur le Cardinal Mazarini:
>
> I have wished, monseigneur, to learn your intentions relating to the existing state of affairs in England. The two kingdoms are so near that France must be interested in our situation, as we are interested in that of France. The English are almost of one mind in contending against the tyranny of Charles and his adherents. Placed by popular confidence at the head of that movement, I can appreciate better than any other its significance and its probable results. I am at present in the midst of war, and am about to deliver a decisive battle against King Charles. I shall gain it, for the hope of the nation and the Spirit of the Lord are with me. This battle won by me, the king will have no further resources in England or in Scotland; and if he is not captured or killed, he will endeavour to pass over into France to recruit soldiers and to refurnish himself with arms and money. France has already received Queen Henrietta, and, unintentionally, doubtless, has maintained a centre of inextinguishable civil war in my country. But Madame Henrietta is a daughter of France and

was entitled to the hospitality of France. As to King Charles, the question must be viewed differently; in receiving and aiding him, France will censure the acts of the English nation, and thus so essentially harm England, and especially the well-being of the government, that such a proceeding will be equivalent to pronounced hostilities.

At this moment Mazarin became very uneasy at the turn which the letter was taking and paused to glance under his eyes at the young man. The latter continued in thought. Mazarin resumed his reading:

It is important, therefore, monseigneur, that I should be informed as to the intentions of France. The interests of that kingdom and those of England, though taking now diverse directions, are very nearly the same. England needs tranquillity at home, in order to consummate the expulsion of her king; France needs tranquillity to establish on solid foundations the throne of her young monarch. You need, as much as we do, that interior condition of repose which, thanks to the energy of our government, we are about to attain.

Your quarrels with the parliament, your noisy dissensions with the princes, who fight for you to-day and to-morrow will fight against you, the popular following directed by the coadjutor, President Blancmesnil, and Councillor Broussel—all that disorder, in short, which pervades the several departments of the state, must lead you to view with uneasiness the possibility of a foreign war; for in that event England, exalted by the enthusiasm of new ideas, will ally herself with Spain, already seeking that alliance. I have therefore believed, monseigneur, knowing your prudence and your personal relation to the events of the present time, that you will choose to hold your forces concentrated in the interior of the French kingdom and leave to her own the new government of England. That neutrality consists simply in excluding King Charles from the territory of France and in

'I know that it is terrible,' said D'Artagnan; 'but when I reflect that we have killed English, Rochellais, Spaniards, nay, even French, who never did us any other harm but to aim at and to miss us, whose only fault was to cross swords with us and to be unable to ward off our blows—I can, on my honour, find an excuse for my share in the murder of that woman.'

'As for me,' said Porthos, 'now that you have reminded me of it, Athos, I have the scene again before me, as if I now were there. Milady was there, as it were, where *you* sit.' (Athos changed colour.) 'I—I was where D'Artagnan stands. I wore a long sword which cut like a Damascus—you remember it, Aramis for you always called it Balizarde. Well, I swear to you, all three, that had the executioner of Bethune—was he not of Bethune?—yes, egad! of Bethune!—not been there, I would have cut off the head of that infamous being without thinking of it, or even after thinking of it. She was a most atrocious woman.'

'And then,' said Aramis, with the tone of philosophical indifference which he had assumed since he had belonged to the church and in which there was more atheism than confidence in God, 'what is the use of thinking of it all? At the last hour we must confess this action and God knows better than we can whether it is a crime, a fault, or a meritorious deed. *I* repent of it? Egad! no. Upon my honour and by the holy cross; I only regret it because she was a woman.'

'The most satisfactory part of the matter,' said D'Artagnan, 'is that there remains no trace of it.'

'She had a son,' observed Athos.

'Oh! yes, I know that,' said D'Artagnan, 'and you mentioned it to me; but who knows what has become of him? If the serpent be dead, why not its brood? Do you think his uncle De Winter would have brought up that young viper? De Winter probably condemned the son as he had done the mother.'

'Then,' said Athos, 'woe to De Winter, for the child had done no harm.'

'May the devil take me, if the child be not dead,' said Porthos. 'There is so much fog in that detestable country, at least so D'Artagnan declares.'

Just as the quaint conclusion reached by Porthos was about to bring back hilarity to faces now more or less clouded, hasty footsteps were heard upon the stair and some one knocked at the door.

'Come in,' cried Athos.

'Nor in the third,' returned Porthos; 'and even when one is killed, one rises again, the proof of which is, that here we are!'

'No,' said Athos, 'it is not Raoul about whom I am anxious, for I trust he will conduct himself like a gentleman; and if he is killed—well, he will die bravely; but hold—should such a misfortune happen—well— ' Athos passed his hand across his pale brow.

'Well?' asked Aramis.

'Well, I shall look upon it as an expiation.'

'Ah!' said D'Artagnan; 'I know what you mean.'

'And I, too,' added Aramis; 'but you must not think of that, Athos; what is past, is past.'

'I don't understand,' said Porthos.

'The affair at Armentières,' whispered D'Artagnan.

'The affair at Armentières?' asked he again.

'Milady.'

'Oh, yes!' said Porthos; 'true, I had forgotten it!'

Athos looked at him intently.

'You have forgotten it, Porthos?' said he.

'Faith! yes, it is so long ago,' answered Porthos.

'This affair does not, then, weigh upon your conscience?'

'Faith, no.'

'And you, D'Artagnan?'

'I—I own that when my mind returns to that terrible period I have no recollection of anything but the rigid corpse of poor Madame Bonancieux. Yes, yes,' murmured he, 'I have often felt regret for the victim, but never the very slightest remorse for the assassin.'

Athos shook his dead doubtfully.

'Consider,' said Aramis, 'if you admit divine justice and its participation in the things of this world, that woman was punished by the will of heaven. We were but the instruments, that is all.'

'But as to free will, Aramis?'

'How acts the judge? He has a free will, yet he fearlessly condemns. What does the executioner? He is master of his arm, yet he strikes without remorse.'

'The executioner!' muttered Athos, as if arrested by some recollection.

refraining from helping him—a stranger to your country—with arms, with money or with troops.

My letter is private and confidential, and for that reason I send it to you by a man who shares my most intimate counsels. It anticipates, through a sentiment which your eminence will appreciate, measures to be taken after the events. Oliver Cromwell considered it more expedient to declare himself to a mind as intelligent as Mazarin's than to a queen admirable for firmness, without doubt, but too much guided by vain prejudices of birth and of divine right.

Farewell, monseigneur; should I not receive a reply in the space of fifteen days, I shall presume my letter will have miscarried.

Oliver Cromwell.

'Mr Mordaunt,' said the cardinal, raising his voice, as if to arouse the dreamer, 'my reply to this letter will be more satisfactory to General Cromwell if I am convinced that all are ignorant of my having given one; go, therefore, and await it at Boulogne-sur-Mer, and promise me to set out to-morrow morning.'

'I promise, my lord,' replied Mordaunt; 'but how many days does your eminence expect me to await your reply?'

'If you do not receive it in ten days you can leave.'

Mordaunt bowed.

'That is not all, sir,' continued Mazarin; 'your private adventures have touched me to the quick; besides, the letter from Mr Cromwell makes you an important person as ambassador; come, tell me, what can I do for you?'

Mordaunt reflected a moment and, after some hesitation, was about to speak, when Bernouin entered hastily and bending down to the ear of the cardinal, whispered:

'My lord, the Queen Henrietta Maria, accompanied by an English noble, is entering the Palais Royal at this moment.'

Mazarin made a bound from his chair, which did not escape the attention of the young man and suppressed the confidence he was about to make.

'Sir,' said the cardinal, 'you have heard me? I fix on Boulogne because I presume that every town in France is indifferent to you; if you prefer another, name it; but you can easily conceive that, surrounded as I am by influences I can only muzzle by discretion, I desire your presence in Paris to be unknown.'

'I go, sir,' said Mordaunt, advancing a few steps to the door by which he had entered.

'No, not that way, I beg, sir,' quickly exclaimed the cardinal, 'be so good as to pass by yonder gallery, by which you can regain the hall. I do not wish you to be seen leaving; our interview must be kept secret.'

Mordaunt followed Bernouin, who led him through the adjacent chamber and left him with a doorkeeper, showing him the way out.

'The prince immediately sent fifty thousand francs to Mazarin, begging him never to write to him again, and offered twenty thousand francs more, on condition that he would never speak to him. What did Mazarin do?'

'Stormed!' suggested Athos.

'Beat the messenger!' cried Porthos.

'Accepted the money!' said D'Artagnan.

'You have guessed it,' answered Aramis; and they all laughed so heartily that the host appeared in order to inquire whether the gentlemen wanted anything; he thought they were fighting.

At last their hilarity calmed down and:

'Faith!' exclaimed D'Artagnan to the two friends, 'you may well wish ill to Mazarin; for I assure you, on his side he wishes you no good.'

'Pooh! really?' asked Athos. 'If I thought the fellow knew me by my name I would be rebaptized, for fear it might be thought I knew him.'

'He knows you better by your actions than your name; he is quite aware that there are two gentlemen who greatly aided the escape of Monsieur de Beaufort, and he has instigated an active search for them, I can answer for it.'

'By whom?'

'By me; and this morning he sent for me to ask me if I had obtained any information.'

'And what did you reply?'

'That I had none as yet; but that I was to dine to-day with two gentlemen, who would be able to give me some.'

'You told him that?' said Porthos, a broad smile spreading over his honest face. 'Bravo! and you are not afraid of that, Athos?'

'No,' replied Athos, 'it is not the search of Mazarin that I fear.'

'Now,' said Aramis, 'tell me a little what you do fear.'

'Nothing for the present; at least, nothing in good earnest.'

'And with regard to the past?' asked Porthos.

'Oh! the past is another thing,' said Athos, sighing; 'the past and the future.'

'Are you afraid for your young Raoul?' asked Aramis.

'Well,' said D'Artagnan, 'one is never killed in a first engagement.'

'Nor in the second,' said Aramis